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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1986-1989

Coverage Date: 1895-1989

Place Coverage: KwaZulu Natal, South Africa

Section Title(S): CONCLUSION

The masculine emphasis on perceived 'Zulu' traits of dominance over women, demanding respect and obedience from them, and the redefinition of the appropriate forms of work (wage labour is seen as acceptable, while cooperative labour in the fields is not) has obvious attractions to KwaDapha men, and is located in rural relationships. Whatever the historical origin of the dual identity of the inhabitants of the area, where people can slide with equal facility into the identity of 'Zulu' or 'Thonga', there is no doubt that the modern impetus propelling men towards a Zulu-style ethnicity is the institution of migrant labour.

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The new form of joking relationship, with overtones of sexual innuendo, personal licence, and humiliation has arisen out of women's resentment of migrant labour. Perhaps this too, has its role model and legitimacy in the now fading mother's brother-sister's son relationship among the Thonga, so celebrated in the anthropological literature. The new form, with its almost ritualised antagonism is particularly apposite, for the relationship which spawns it is the pivotal one in male/female interaction today. Migrant labour separates men from women, and provides the means whereby men can strengthen their position of gender dominance. Migrancy is also the vehicle for the acquisition of knowledge of 'Zulu' custom and behaviour, and tools of the trade of women's oppression at Kosi Bay.

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The paradox is that migrancy (and its attendant concept of 'Zuluness') brings in the money without which no family could survive, but the price is female subordination. In contrast, the Thonga idiom speaks of women's defiance, independence and emancipation. The women of Kosi Bay have created a

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sense of solidarity which is tempered by their bitter-sweet dependence on their menfolk. It is a classic case of conjunction and disjunction.

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A final irony of the situation is that male dominance is gained in the most alienating of experiences, for migrancy generally means living and working with strangers in hostels and factories in a hostile environment. Their womenfolk have a different set of experiences. Their relationships are crafted communally, in socially rewarding circumstances, such as work parties or shellfish harvesting expeditions. It is this, above all else, that gives such resilience to women in the domestic struggle, and to their chosen metaphor, the mysterious Thonga woman.

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